

“ I have no ambition left. I feel pity for those who killed my son. My anger is directed at the masterminds.”

SEVANTILAL PAREKH



pictures of Sunil, Reshma and their two daughters. “I don’t know if it was premonition. But my daughter-in-law got this calendar made just two months before the horrific incident,” he says.

It’s been one year, but for Sevantilal and his wife, it could well have been one day. His wife Sarla, 75, was so angered by the attacks that she filed a PIL outlining a 12-point plan on how to prevent them in future. She even provided the seed money for Citizens Take Charge, an initiative that wants accountability from the Government. “We are pursuing it, but for all the talk, the Government machinery is extremely slow,” he says. He should be angry but Sevantilal says he feels nothing but pity for the men who killed his son and daughter-in-law. “They are misguided. My real anger is directed at those who brainwash them.” Though haunted by his son’s memory every day, Sevantilal says he’s surprised at how he’s found the strength to carry on. “Sometimes, when I’m laughing or talking, I wonder how I’m doing it.”

by Jhilmil Motihar

THE REBOOTING OF A SOUL

DEEPAK BAGLA, 47

WHAT HAPPENED: Was trapped in his room at the Oberoi

On the night of 26/11, Deepak Bagla was late for dinner. His reserved table with the seaside view at the Kandahar, the Oberoi’s Indian restaurant, had been taken. Dressed in blue jeans and white half-sleeved T-shirt and monk shoes, the director of a British private equity firm was looking to unwind with a leisurely dinner at the end of a hectic day. Accompanied by his British associate Michael Queen, he settled for a table near the kitchen for a meal of grilled fish. At around 9.40 p.m. when the duo were waiting for the bill, they began hearing shots which Bagla thought were firecrackers. The crackle grew louder and in three minutes, there were gunshots and screams from inside the Kandahar as the diners sitting by the windows were gunned down.

“Michael! Run!” Bagla gasped. They shot past the kitchen doors and ran into Bagla’s room on the 12th floor.

The firing continued and blasts reverberated like quakes through the atrium of the 12-storeyed hotel. Bagla took a chair and wedged it as a barricade against the door and spent the next few minutes creating a bunker in the room. He filled both basins with water and instructed his colleague not to use the flush because the noise could give them away. It was the start of an agonising 40-hour odyssey. From outside, Bagla heard a foreign lady shouting for help from her room on the same floor. Her cries continued into the next day, growing progressively weaker and finally stopping.

The banker kept his composure throughout, but cracked only twice. The first time when he called his parents in Delhi the next morning and his mother dropped the phone on hearing where he was; the second distressing event was when the TV went on the blink. “It was like being cut off from the rest of the world.” Throughout the ordeal, Bagla’s phone and Blackberry, kept on a constant charge, were lifelines to the outside

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“ 26/11 made me more resolute about doing something for people. I am more at peace with myself today.”

DEEPAK BAGLA